

The Borrowed Bicycle

It started with a bicycle left outside a café. No one knew who it belonged to. Everyone had a theory.

CEFR Level A2

Book 3 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small street in Bristol. The Crescent Café and the surrounding neighbourhood.

Genre: Comedy / Community Drama

Characters

- Lena — 34. The café owner. Practical, dry sense of humour, secretly romantic.
- Dev — 40. Regular customer. Accountant. Observant and methodical.
- Caro — 28. Art student. Enthusiastic, slightly chaotic.
- Mr. Petersen — 71. Retired. Has an opinion about everything.

The bicycle appeared on a Monday morning, leaning against the wall outside the Crescent Café.

It was an old green bicycle — the kind with a basket at the front and no gears. There was no lock on it, and no note.

Lena noticed it when she opened the café at eight. She looked left and right along the street. No one was paying it any attention.

She went inside and made coffee.

At half past eight, Dev arrived for his usual flat white and sat in the window seat. He looked at the bicycle.

'Is that yours?' he asked.

'No,' Lena said.

'Someone probably leaned it there meaning to come back,' Dev said. He had a methodical way of speaking — slowly, as if each sentence was a calculation.

'Or they forgot it,' Lena said.

'People don't forget bicycles.' He looked at it again.

'Unless they were in a hurry. Or upset.'

'You're turning a bicycle into a drama,' Lena said.

Dev shrugged. 'Everything is a drama if you look at it long enough.'

Caro arrived at that moment, slightly out of breath, her bag over one shoulder and paint on her jacket.

'Whose is the bicycle?' she asked.

'I think it's a gift,' Caro said, hanging up her jacket and sitting down.

'A gift for whom?' Lena asked.

'For whoever needs it. Like — street art, but useful.'

She looked at Dev. 'Or maybe someone left it and doesn't want it back.'

'That's sad,' Dev said.

'Or liberating,' Caro said. 'Sometimes you just want to leave something behind and walk away.'

Lena poured their coffees. She had her own theory but she kept it to herself.

Mr. Petersen arrived at nine, as he did every day, and ordered black coffee and a croissant.

He looked at the bicycle for a long time through the window.

'That bicycle has been here before,' he said.

Everyone looked at him.

'Last summer,' he said. 'Same bicycle. Green, with the basket. It was here for about a week, then someone collected it.'

'Who?' Dev asked.

'A young man,' Mr. Petersen said. 'Dark hair. Tall. He came on a Saturday.'

'You remember all that from last summer?' Caro said. Mr. Petersen looked at her. 'I have been coming to this café for eleven years. I notice things.'

Mr. Petersen has seen this bicycle before. It was here last summer.

At eleven o'clock, Lena went outside to check the bicycle more carefully.

She lifted the basket. Underneath, taped to the inside, was a small piece of paper.

She peeled it off carefully. The handwriting was very small.

It said: If you need it, use it. If not, leave it for the next person. The lock code is 1934. — J.

Lena took the note inside and showed the others.

Caro clapped her hands. 'I knew it. I said it was a gift.'

Dev was studying the note. '1934,' he said. 'An interesting code. That's a significant year.'

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A mysterious bicycle appears outside Lena's café.

Dev googled 1934 on his phone. He read out a list of events.

'The Dionne quintuplets were born. The Night of the Long Knives. The first Driving Test in Britain. F. Scott Fitzgerald—'

'I don't think J. is giving us a history lesson,' Lena said.

'No,' Dev agreed. 'It's just a code. But why that number specifically?'

'Maybe it's a year that means something to them,' Caro said.

'1934 would make a person ninety years old,' Mr. Petersen said quietly. Everyone looked at him. 'Or,' he continued, 'it could be the year of something else. A house. A road. A birthday.'

The next morning, the bicycle was gone.

Lena was slightly disappointed, although she did not say so.

At ten o'clock, a woman in her forties came in for a coffee. She had a cycling helmet under her arm.

'The green bicycle outside,' she said. 'Is that yours?'

'No,' Lena said. 'There's a note. It's for anyone who needs it.'

The woman nodded slowly. 'I took it this morning. Early. I hope that was all right.'

'Of course,' Lena said. 'That's the idea. Did it — was it all right?'

The woman smiled. 'It was lovely, actually. I used to cycle. Years ago.'

The woman — her name was Bea — returned the bicycle at lunchtime.

She also brought a small bunch of flowers, which she put in the basket.

'For the next person,' she said.

Lena put the flowers in a jam jar on the counter instead. 'I want them to last a bit longer,' she said.

Bea laughed. 'My husband used to say I was too sentimental about flowers. He said they were designed to die quickly.' She paused. 'He died last year.'

Lena was quiet. Then: 'I'm sorry.' 'It's all right,' Bea said. 'He was right about the flowers, though.'

By the end of the week, Dev had — without anyone asking him to — created a small log of the bicycle's movements.

He showed it to Lena on Friday morning.

It had columns: Date, Time Out, Time Back, Notes.

The bicycle had been borrowed five times. Three times by strangers, once by Caro (to pick up an art supply she had forgotten), and once by Mr. Petersen, who had simply sat on it outside for fifteen minutes without going anywhere.

'I wanted to remember what it felt like,' Mr. Petersen said, when they asked him about the last entry.

On Saturday, the café was quiet in the afternoon. Lena was wiping down tables when Caro asked:

'You said you had your own theory about the bicycle. What is it?'

Lena folded her cloth. She looked at the bicycle outside.

'I think J. left it for a specific person,' she said.

'Someone who used to come here. Someone who maybe stopped coming.'

'Like a message?' Caro said.

'Like a door left open,' Lena said. 'In case they come back.'

Caro was quiet for a moment. Then: 'That's the most romantic thing I've heard all week.'

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The whole street develops theories about the borrowed bicycle.

Lena picked up her cloth and went back to wiping tables.

A door left open, in case they come back. Lena's theory is the most romantic.

At three o'clock on that same Saturday, a man walked past the café.

He stopped when he saw the bicycle.

He stood on the pavement for almost a full minute, just looking at it.

Then he came inside.

He was in his mid-thirties, with dark hair. He ordered a coffee and sat near the window.

He kept looking at the bicycle outside.

Dev, who had come back for a second coffee, leaned across to Lena. 'Dark hair,' he said quietly. 'Tall. Like Mr. Petersen described.'

Lena brought the man his coffee.

'Is that bicycle something to do with your café?' he asked.

'Not exactly,' Lena said. 'Someone left it. There's a note — it's for anyone who needs it.'

The man looked at the bicycle for a long moment.

'I know who left it,' he said.

The café was quiet. Lena stayed at the table.

'It was my grandmother,' the man said. 'She used to live on this street. She died in January. That's her bicycle. She left it to the street, basically.'

'Her name was Jean,' the man said. His name was Tom. He had grown up on the street — three doors from the café.

'She was ninety last year,' Tom said.

Dev put down his cup.

'She was born in 1934,' Tom said.

Dev looked at Lena. Lena looked at Dev.

'The lock code,' Lena said. Tom nodded.

'She chose it herself. She was very... deliberate about things. She knew she was leaving it behind. She wanted someone to use it.'

Caro had come back in from the kitchen. She was very still.

Tom told them about his grandmother.

Jean had lived on the street for sixty years. She had cycled to work every day until she was seventy-eight. She had stopped when her balance became unreliable.

'She used to say that the bicycle had given her more freedom than anything else in her life,' Tom said. 'She wanted it to keep doing that — for someone else.'

He looked at Dev's log on the table. Dev had left it out.

'Is this — did you track it?' Tom asked.

'Just informally,' Dev said, slightly embarrassed.

Tom looked at the list. He read each entry. His face was still.

'Five people used it,' Tom said. He read the notes Dev had written.

'Bea — brought flowers.' He smiled. 'Mr. Petersen — sat on it for fifteen minutes.' He laughed quietly. 'That's — that's exactly what Gran would have wanted.'

Mr. Petersen, who had come in for his afternoon coffee, was listening.

'She sounds like a sensible woman,' Mr. Petersen said.

'She was,' Tom said. 'She was the most sensible person I've ever known.'

He looked at the bicycle again. 'I'm glad someone is using it. I was worried it would just... sit there.'

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What begins as a mystery becomes a small act of
neighbourhood connection.

Tom stayed for another hour. He told them about Jean — her garden, her opinions on the neighbourhood, her habit of writing notes in small handwriting.

'She left notes everywhere,' he said. 'In books, under plates, in pockets of old coats. Always short. Always to the point.'

Caro was sketching something in her notebook while he talked.

'Do you mind if I draw something based on this?' she asked.

Tom looked at her sketchbook. 'What kind of thing?'

'Something for the café. About the bicycle. About Jean.' She showed him a rough sketch.

He looked at it for a long time. 'No,' he said. 'I don't mind at all.'

Three weeks later, Caro brought a small framed painting to the café.

It showed a green bicycle leaning against a wall. In the basket were flowers.

At the bottom, in small letters, it said: For whoever needs it. — J., 1934-2024.

Lena hung it on the wall near the window — the window where Dev always sat.

Tom came in to see it. He stood in front of it for a long time.

'She would have said it was too much fuss,' he said.

'She would have been wrong,' Lena said.

Tom smiled. 'Yes. She would have been.'

When autumn came, Lena moved the bicycle inside at night to protect it from the rain.

Dev updated his log with a new column: Weather notes.

The bicycle was borrowed thirty-one times between May and November.

Some people brought it back with a small addition — a bell, once; a small bunch of herbs from someone's garden; a card that said Thank you.

Lena kept all of these things on the shelf behind the counter.

'You're building a collection,' Caro said one day.

'It's not a collection,' Lena said. 'It's evidence.'

'Of what?' 'Of people being decent.'

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. leaning against	yaslanmış
2. basket	sepet
3. gears	vites, dişli
4. paying attention	dikkat etmek
5. usual	her zamanki
6. methodical	metodik, düzenli
7. calculation	hesap
8. drama	dram, büyütülmüş olay
9. shrugged	omuz silkti
10. slightly out of breath	hafif nefes nefese
11. hanging up	astı
12. liberating	özgürleştirici
13. leave something behind	bir şeyi geride bırakmak
14. walk away	uzaklaşmak
15. kept it to herself	kendi içinde tuttu
16. croissant	kruasan
17. collected it	onu aldı
18. dark hair	siyah saç
19. notice things	şeyleri fark eder
20. last summer	geçen yaz
21. lifted	kaldırdı
22. taped to	bantla yapıştırılmış
23. peeled off	soydu, çıkardı
24. significant	anlamli, önemli
25. clapped her hands	el çırpı
26. googled	internette aradı
27. read out	sesli okudu
28. specifically	özellikle
29. means something	bir şey ifade etmek
30. quintuplets	beşiz
31. 1934 is just a code. But why that number?	theory? Mr. Petersen has a
32. disappointed	hayal kırıklığına uğramış
33. cycling helmet	bisiklet kaskı
34. took it	aldı
35. used to	eskiden
36. lovely	güzeldi
37. bunch of flowers	çiçek demeti
38. jam jar	reçel kavanozu

39. last a bit longer	biraz daha dayanmak
40. sentimental	duygusal, hissi
41. designed to	... için tasarlanmış
42. log	kayıt defteri
43. columns	sütunlar
44. art supply	sanat malzemesi
45. entry	kayıt, giriş
46. movements	hareketler
47. wiping down	siliyor
48. folded	katladı
49. cloth	bez
50. specific person	belirli bir kişi
51. romantic	romantik
52. door left open	açık bırakılan kapı
53. pavement	kaldırım
54. mid-thirties	otuzlarının ortasında
55. kept looking	bakmaya devam etti
56. leaned across	eğildi
57. described	tarif etti
58. something to do with	... ile ilgili
59. basically	esasen, temelde
60. left it to	... e bıraktı
61. grandmother	büyükanne
62. long moment	uzun bir an
63. deliberate	kasıtlı, düşünerek yapılan
64. lock code	kilit kodu
65. grew up	büyüdü
66. three doors	üç kapı ileride
67. still	hareketsiz
68. balance	denge
69. unreliable	güvenilmez
70. freedom	özgürlük
71. informally	gayri resmi olarak
72. embarrassed	utanmış
73. track	takip etmek
74. sensible	akıllı, mantıklı
75. glad	memnun
76. exactly what she would	have wanted

77. worried	endişeliydi
78. sit there	orada durmak
79. to the point	konuya odaklı
80. rough sketch	kaba çizim
81. sketching	çizim yapıyor
82. based on	... e dayalı
83. opinions	görüşler
84. framed painting	çerçevesiz tablo
85. fuss	yaygara, abartı
86. hung it on the wall	duvara astı
87. would have said	demiş olurdu
88. 1934-2024	doğum-ölüm yılları
89. protect from	... den korumak
90. addition	ekleme
91. bell	zil
92. herbs	otlar
93. decent	iyi kalpli, insanımsı
94. evidence	kanıt

After-Reading Activities

Page 19 — February

In February, a woman came into the café and asked about the bicycle.

She was in her twenties. She looked tired.

'I saw the painting,' she said. 'I wanted to know if it was real.'

'It's real,' Lena said. She pointed to the bicycle, which was inside because of the cold.

The woman looked at it. 'I've just moved to the city,' she said. 'I don't know anyone here. I saw the painting and I thought — that's a kind street.'

Lena made her a coffee. 'It is,' she said. 'Sit down.'

The woman sat. She looked out of the window at the street.

'What was she like?' she asked. 'Jean?'

Vocabulary Support

pointed to
işaret etti

kind street
nazik bir sokak

just moved to
yeni taşındı

real
gerçek

tired
yorgun

She moved to the city and saw the painting. She thought: that's a kind street.

Page 20 — The Street

Lena told her what she knew about Jean — the cycling, the notes, the 1934 code, the deliberate farewell.

The woman listened with both hands around her coffee cup.

'I want to borrow the bicycle,' she said. 'When it's warmer.'

'Of course,' Lena said. 'That's what it's for.'

Dev was in the window seat, pretending to read his newspaper.

Lena caught his eye. He raised an eyebrow.

She raised one back. The unspoken conversation: see? This is still working.

Outside, the street was grey and cold. Inside, the café was warm.

The bicycle leaned against the wall and waited — patiently, the way good things do.

Vocabulary Support

farewell

veda

pretending to read

okuyormuş gibi yapıyor

caught his eye

göz göze geldi

unspoken

söylenmemiş

patiently

sabırla

The bicycle waits — patiently, the way good things do. Jean would approve.

Answer Key

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. methodical

A. özgürleştirici

2. liberating

B. metodik

3. deliberate

C. kanıt

4. evidence

D. kasıtlı

5. sensible

E. duygusal

6. sentimental

F. akıllı

7. decent

G. iyi kalpli

8. grateful

H. minnettar

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

borrowed — note — code — deliberate — evidence — theory

1. The bicycle was left outside the café with no lock and no _____.

2. Lena found a small piece of paper in the basket — a _____.

3. The lock _____ was 1934 — Jean's birth year.